

The Voice Express

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INTERNATIONAL

'Matters of Money': 43 Organisations Demand India's Withdrawal From Bilateral Investment Agreement with Israel Amidst Ongoing Genocide In Gaza

On 8th September 2025, India and Israel's finance ministers signed a Bilateral Investment Agreement in New Delhi. Forty-three organisations and forty-seven individuals released an open letter calling on India to withdraw from the treaty, calling it a material contribution to an ongoing genocide in Gaza.

BY MOULI SHARMA



Photo: Mouli Sharma

On 8th September 2025, India & Israel's Finance Ministers signed a vague and opaque investment treaty in New Delhi that doubles down on the two nations' existing trade relations with an increased focus on incentivising and protecting investors, all amidst an ongoing genocide being perpetrated by Israel along the Gaza Strip.

15th September 2025, New Delhi : On 13th September 2025, 43 organisations and 47 individuals, including academics, journalists, and activists released an open letter calling upon the government of India to withdraw from the recently signed Bilateral Investment Agreement (BIA) between India and Israel amidst the ongoing genocide in Gaza.

Though the treaty has not yet been made accessible to the public, with neither participating country's foreign affairs portfolio having listed it as an active bilateral agreement at time of writing, the concerned organisations viewed protesting it as a necessary step.

"Any strengthening of relationship between India and Israel needs to be condemned," said Anjali S. from Indians for Palestine explaining the rationale behind calling for a withdrawal from the treaty before its release to the public. "No matter how good or bad, severe or non-severe the consequences are of the same," she finished.

She also added that the treaty's unavailability and the opaque process of India's international policy itself was an added cause for concern.

Specifically, the letter criticised the BIA's latent encouragement of the two countries defence trade, which saw its all-time high at the start of the 'Israel-Gaza conflict' in 2023.

After a consortium led by Gautam Adani's Adani Ports and Special Economic Zone Ltd (APSEZ) acquired the rights to operate the Haifa Port Company Ltd from the Government of Israel with an overall investment of US\$ 1.18 billion, India's weapons imports from Israel nearly doubled from 134 million USD in 2022 to a peak 265 million USD in 2023.

Ironically, this same financial year marked a decline of India's own exports to Israel.

"India's trade with Israel began tapering off in 2023," wrote Ishaan Gera for MoneyControl in June this year. "India's exports to Israel fell from a peak of \$7.6 million in 2022 to \$6.1 million in 2023 and to \$2.1 million in 2024."

India's bilateral arms and ammunitions trade has grown 33 times over the past decade of the Modi regime, from 5.6 million USD in 2015 to 185 million USD in 2024, but except explosives and base metals, these constitute largely of imports. Since the onset of Israel's genocidal destruction of the Gaza Strip, disturbing allegations regarding the nature of Israel's weapons industry have triggered international condemnation , including the use of untested Artificial Intelligence (AI) on long range lethal weapons being used on Palestinians.

In the meeting on Monday, Sitharaman brought up the Ramot Junction Shooting that took place in Jerusalem earlier the same day.

"Finance Minister Smt. Nirmala Sitharaman expressed her condolences over the loss of innocent lives in terrorist attack in Israel today (sic)," read the PIB release. "She also mentioned about the shared value of civilizational ethos of two countries which contributed to the global peace. Both Ministers acknowledged the threat of terrorism faced by both the countries and expressed solidarity with each other (sic)."

The terrorist attack in question took place at the bus junction in Ramot, an Israeli settlement in East Jerusalem along the Occupied West Bank (OWB), where two gunmen suspected to be from neighbouring Palestinian villages opened fire at the public during morning rush hour, killing 5 and injuring 21. Notably, 6 Indians had just died in a gunfight at the Manipur-Assam border the prior morning on the 7th of September 2025, but the incident remained unmentioned through the discussion on India and Israel's shared struggles with terrorism and the loss of innocent lives.

On the night of the 6th of September, at about 8:30 PM, 13 Palestinians were killed and dozens injured while waiting for aid in As Sudaniya area in western North Gaza. The next day, on the 7th of September, Israeli strikes killed at least 50 people and destroyed at least 50 buildings in Gaza, as reported by Vatican News . On 8 September, the same day the terrorist attack that Sitharaman condemned took place in Israel killing 5, six Palestinians, including three males, were killed and 15 injured while waiting for supply trucks along the Morag corridor, south of Khan Younis.

Neither minister commented on any of the above.

In fact, no mention was made of the ongoing genocide in Gaza being perpetrated by the Israeli government at all, which has so far killed over 65,000 people , or the eight decade long occupation of Palestinian land which has historically been the subject of much diplomatic criticism from India and other formerly colonised nations.

In their four-page letter condemning the agreement and calling upon the Government of India (GOI) to withdraw from it, 90 signatories have criticised this diplomatic 180, and compared the ruling Bharatiya Janata Party's politics to that of the Netanyahu run Likud in Israel.

"India's current stance abandons a proud legacy. Historically, India was a steadfast supporter of Palestinian self-determination, among the first to recognise Palestine in 1988. That position grew out of India's anti-colonial struggle and commitment to justice for all peoples. Today, narrow geopolitical gains and the BJP's majoritarian politics, akin to Israel's, have replaced that legacy," the letter says.

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Notable signatories of the letter include Palestine solidarity organisations like Indians for Palestine and Indian Dancers for Gaza's Children ; leftist organisations such as COLLECTIVE (Delhi) , Communist Party of India (Marxist-Leninist) (CPIML) , Communist Party of India (Marxist-Leninist) New Democracy ; feminist organisations such as Feminists in Resistance (Kolkata) , Forum Against Oppression of Women , & the National Federation of Indian Women (NFIW) ; alongside many others.

In July earlier this year, the same network of organisations along with civil society members also came together at Nehru Place to protest India's trade of arms and labour with Israel, triggering mob violence from an enraged public overrun with national sentiment. Then too, the message echoing in the silent gathering's placards and posters was one of contempt for India and Israel's economic ties.

"There was a time when India stood with Palestinians; it stood for Palestine's freedom," said activist Paran Amitava after the forced dispersal of protestors at the Nehru Place event. "In today's date, the Indian government has joined hands with Adani to sell Israel arms and ammunition, this is how they make money," she said.

"When it comes to matters of money, there is no room for solidarity."



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